Alignment vs. Standardization Diagnostic

Purpose

Determine where consistency is necessary, where alignment is sufficient, and where local variation can legitimately remain.

What It Is

A structured way to distinguish shared outcomes, requirements, interfaces, and evidence from methods that may not need to be identical.

What It Is Not

An argument against standards, a mandate for local autonomy, or a scoring system for process consistency.

Diagnostic Lens

A. Establish What Must Align

Start with what the system must achieve and what must hold across boundaries before deciding how much of the method needs to be the same.

What must be true when the work is complete?

Define the result before discussing how everyone should perform the work.

Where does variation create meaningful risk, confusion, incompatibility, ambiguity, or failure?

Identify the boundary that needs alignment without assuming the underlying methods must be identical.

01 Outcome

What must be true when the work is complete?

Define the result the system must reliably produce before prescribing the method.

02 Requirement

What is genuinely non-negotiable?

Consider legal, regulatory, quality, safety, customer, technical, contractual, and organizational requirements.

03 Interface

Where must different parts of the system connect?

Consider inputs, outputs, handoffs, data, terminology, timing, ownership, escalation, and acceptance criteria.

04 Evidence

What must demonstrate that the requirement was met?

Identify evidence that must be comparable, reliable, retrievable, or interpretable across the system.

05 Variation

What is different today?

Describe the actual variation without assuming that the difference itself is a problem.

06 Consequence

What happens because it is different?

Look for measurable risk, failure, rework, incompatibility, ambiguity, cost, delay—or no meaningful consequence.

07 Local Value

What does the variation enable?

Consider technology, workflow, capability, regulation, customer, scale, geography, and local operating conditions.

08 Standardization

What specifically becomes better by making this the same?

Name the problem standardization would solve rather than treating consistency itself as the outcome.

Observations / Evidence

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B. Test the Need for Standardization

Variation is not automatically a defect. Establish what differs, what consequence that difference creates, and what value the variation may preserve.

Decision Frame

DOES VARIATION CREATE A REAL PROBLEM?		
Establish the consequence before prescribing sameness.		
Yes The variation creates a meaningful problem.	**Question** Does the method itself need to match?	**No** Preserve the local method unless another requirement demands change.
Standardize Make the method consistent where the method itself is necessary.	**Align** Align the requirement, interface, evidence, or outcome while allowing the method to vary.	**Allow Variation** Keep legitimate local variation where it creates value or carries no meaningful risk.

C. Define the Operating Boundary

Make the boundary explicit: what must be common, what must be identical, what may vary, and how the system will remain governed.

Align What must be common?	**Standardize** What specifically must be done the same way?
Allow Variation What may legitimately differ?	**Govern** How will we know the boundaries still work?

What problem would standardization solve that alignment alone would not?

OPEN LAB NOTE: Consistency has value when variation creates a meaningful problem. But consistency is not automatically evidence of control. A system can align around outcomes, requirements, interfaces, and evidence while allowing local methods to differ where that variation creates value or carries no meaningful risk.

Use it. Challenge it. Change it. Make it better. Share what you learned.

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